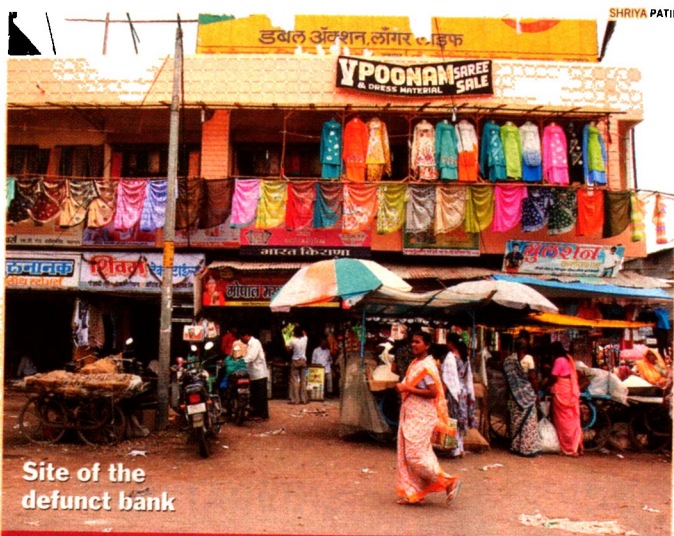


# ABETTING SUICIDE AND PLOTTING MURDER, A NEW SKELETON IS TUMBLING OUT OF PATIL'S CLOSET EVERY DAY



Site of the defunct bank

## BANK SCANDAL

In 1974, she helped set up the Pratibha Mahila Sahakari Bank to help women. By 1995, the bank was declared weak by the RBI. By February 2003, the RBI cancelled its licence due to high NPAs and a negative net worth. The employees' union alleged that the bank lent money to members of Patil's family who failed to return Rs 224.5 lakh.

## CONGRESS DEFENCE

Dasmunshi says: "The bank was founded by her but she was not the first chief promoter. The bank ran well till 1993. The RBI report does not indicate any personal responsibility, liability or strictures against Pratibhatai."

Strange as it may seem, there is not a trace of celebration even at the Patil mansion in Jalgaon. In fact, there is stifled anger. Says Jalgaon District Congress spokesperson Vilas Patil: "Tai, as she is referred to, is a *meethi chhuri* (sweet knife). Although she speaks very sweetly, her intentions are never noble. She has always tried to crush promising people in the party and promoted her own kin." She espoused all the right causes—education, empowerment of women and rural development. Her family runs 18 educational institutions including schools, colleges and technical training institutions. She also started a bank for women and promoted the concept of working women's hostels. For farmers, she set up a sugar factory. But intentions have not translated into goodwill. Vilas adds that he has complained against her, but to no avail. Congressmen in Jalgaon believe that it is because of her that the party has lost its identity. Allegations of ticket being given to her younger brother G.N. Patil to contest the Lok Sabha polls twice—he lost both times—are rife. Her nephew, similarly, was foisted for the Panchayat and zila parishad polls.

In 1974, she helped set up the Pratibha Mahila Sahakari



Rajni Patil (centre) with Sonia

## MURDER MYSTERY

In August 2005, Jalgaon Congress leader Vishram Patil told the party high command about misuse of funds by Pratibha's brother G.N. Patil. On September 21, Vishram was killed outside his house. His wife Rajni alleged G.N. Patil's involvement and pleaded for justice. She met Sonia Gandhi in January 2006. MoS for home Manikrao Gavit intervened and HC ordered a CBI probe.

## CONGRESS DEFENCE

Dasmunshi says: "No FIR has been lodged against her brother. We must wait for the CBI report. In Haren Pandya's murder case, his father blames Narendra Modi. Does the BJP accept it? How can it have double-standards?"

Bank for empowering women. While it seems to have done well for the first two decades, since 1995 the bank has been declared "weak" by the RBI. In February 2003, the RBI cancelled its "licence to carry on banking business" as the bank's paid-up share capital was negative, its assets had eroded and gross non-performing assets amounted to Rs 391.20 lakh. In a memorandum—copies of which are being circulated by Congressmen from Jalgaon—the employees' union complained that founder-chairperson Pratibha "facilitated loans without surety to her own relatives" and despite the fact that the bank was under rehabilitation, got interest on loans waived. The bank set up for empowering women had extended loans to men and women from the Patil family amounting to Rs 224.49 lakh, which were not returned.

The Sant Muktabai Sahakari Sakhar Karkhana Ltd. (SSK), Jalgaon, was set up by her along with a few others in 1980 to help farmers take the cooperative route to prosperity. The project took off only in 1994-95, with a loan from the Mumbai Central District Cooperative Bank (MDCB). It never broke even. Indeed, soon after Sonia visited the factory in 1999, it shut down and owes the MDCB Rs 17.70 crore. The loan was